WISE



G20+ SCORECARD REPORT 2026

12 months left:
Progress towards direct access and price transparency



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When Wise started, the problem was simple. Sending money across borders was too expensive, too slow and too hard to understand. People were told a transfer was “free”, only to lose money in a marked-up exchange rate. They waited days for payments that should have moved much faster. The system was built around borders, intermediaries and opacity, while customers needed something much simpler: money that moves quickly, safely, cheaply and transparently.

That is why the G20 Roadmap for Enhancing Cross-Border Payments matters. It turned a problem that millions of people experience every day into a shared international priority. Six years on, there has been real progress. Payment systems have modernised. More countries are improving competitiveness by opening national payment schemes to non-bank payment service providers. Regulators are paying closer attention to the true cost – hidden fees and all – of international payments. The direction is right.

But the outcome is still not good enough.

This year’s report expands beyond the G20 to include ten additional markets that have large global remittance flows. Looking at G20+ markets gives a fuller picture of where progress is being made, where reform is stuck, and where people are still paying a very high price.

The findings show a mixed picture. On direct access, some markets now prove that regulated non-banks can connect to payment systems directly and settle without unnecessary dependence on intermediary banks.

> The test should always be customer outcomes. Did the payment get cheaper? Did it arrive faster? Could the customer understand the full cost before authorising it?

This is not theoretical. It has been done, and where it has been done well, payments have become faster, cheaper and more resilient. But in too many jurisdictions, non-banks remain locked out of the payment infrastructure. Everywhere the payment system remains a closed infrastructure for lenders, competition is not emerging and the outcomes for end users don’t improve.

On transparency, the gap is even clearer. Hidden FX fees are still the largest invisible cost in international payments. In 2026, consumers and businesses are projected to lose almost $295 billion to exchange rate markups they often never see. That is money taken from families, exporters, students, freelancers and small businesses, usually without a clear explanation at the point they make the payment. No G20 market receives the highest transparency score in this year’s report. Rules on paper are not enough if customers still cannot see the full price before they press send.

There is, however, a positive story in the data too. Some banks and money transfer operators are already showing that better transparency is possible. This is particularly true in Italy and Indonesia, where many banks are leading the way in transparency. They are giving customers clearer information about fees and exchange rate margins, and they deserve recognition for that. This should be celebrated, not treated as a niche exception. Transparent firms prove that showing customers their fees openly is not too hard, too technical nor commercially impossible. Regulators should continue to require and encourage this behaviour until it becomes the norm across the market.

The UK has a particular role to play. As it prepares to take the G20 presidency in 2027, it has an opportunity to help shape the next phase of the Roadmap. The first Roadmap was necessarily broad: it had to map a complex global problem and build consensus. Roadmap 2.0 should be more focused. It should concentrate on reforms that customers can actually feel: full upfront disclosure of the cost of an international payment, including FX markups; direct access to payment systems for regulated non-banks; and clear implementation expectations so that reforms move from policy papers into payment journeys for real people and businesses.

The test should always be customer outcomes. Did the payment get cheaper? Did it arrive faster? Could the customer understand the full cost before authorising it? Could more providers compete on equal infrastructure terms? If the answer is no, then the work is not finished.

The next year is important. Governments, regulators, banks, non-banks and payment system operators all have a part to play. The countries and firms have made progress to show that better international payments are achievable. Now the task is to make that progress consistent, measurable and real for the people and businesses moving money across borders every day.

Kristo Käärmann
Co-founder and CEO
Wise

OVERVIEW & EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Six years after the launch of the G20 Roadmap for Enhancing Cross-Border Payments, its objectives remain urgent. Cross-border payments continue to be slower, more expensive and less transparent than domestic payments, making international trade more expensive than it needs to be, impeding progress on financial inclusion and constraining economic growth. With twelve months remaining before most of the Roadmap's end-2027 targets, attention must now move decisively from international policy development to implementation at jurisdiction level.

The Financial Stability Board's 2025 progress report reached a similar conclusion: considerable policy work has been completed, but it has not yet delivered sufficient improvements for end users. We welcome the recognition that the Roadmap work should continue beyond 2027, but that should not be a reason to reduce the tempo in the meantime, and we look forward to the UK's G20 Presidency as a pivotal moment in resetting the focus on delivering outcomes on the Roadmap.

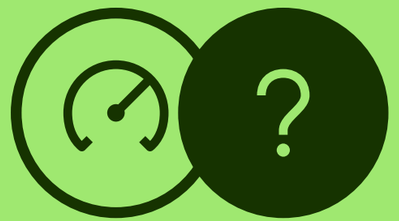
This is the third edition of Wise's G20 Scorecard Report, which expands the coverage of countries beyond the G20 to reflect the importance of remittance corridors rather than institutional boundaries. We have partnered with FXC Intelligence to identify the five largest non-G20 remittance-sending markets into the G20, namely the United Arab Emirates, Hong Kong, Spain, Kuwait and Malaysia, and the five largest receiving markets for remittances from the G20, being the Philippines, Nigeria, Guatemala, Pakistan and Bangladesh. Selected using remittance data anchored to IMF Balance of Payments statistics, these markets provide a fuller picture of how payment systems affect people and businesses across the complete payment journey. Thailand is included separately as a special focus following engagement with the Bank of Thailand. Its importance to regional trade, tourism and remittances, makes it a valuable example outside of the G20. Thailand's inclusion also demonstrates how constructive engagement between regulators and market participants can help extend the Roadmap's impact lessons beyond formal G20 membership.

Progress on direct access under Building Block 10 remains positive but uneven. Under this revised Scorecard, only seven of the 19 G20 markets assessed – Brazil, Indonesia, Japan, Mexico, Türkiye, the United Kingdom and the European Union – receive the highest rating of 5/5, with the UAE and Philippines also achieving the highest score in the additional markets covered in this report. In these markets, Non-Bank Payment Service Providers (NBPSPs) can access domestic payment systems directly, that access has been adopted in practice, and participants can settle through an account at the Central Bank. Elsewhere, NBPSPs remain dependent on commercial banks for at least part of the clearing or settlement process. The additional markets present a similarly mixed picture: several have developed inclusive instant payment systems or enabled some form of non-bank participation, but independent settlement at the Central Bank remains limited, or commercial banks are required to complete an FX payment. Infrastructure modernisation is progressing beyond the G20, but technical connectivity alone does not provide the operational independence required for full direct access.

Progress on price transparency under Building Block 2 is more concerning. No G20 market receives a 5/5 rating in 2026, nor the additional 10 markets in this report. Seven of the G20+ markets have comprehensive upfront disclosure requirements but this has not yet resulted in a change of provider behaviour, which is the new criterion for 5/5. Half of the 30 jurisdictions in this report receive 1/5 or a 0/5 score, meaning that their frameworks may require broad disclosure without specifically identifying FX markups as a cost to the customer. The additional markets reveal the same underlying problem: providers may disclose a transaction fee and the exchange rate applied while leaving customers unable to identify or compare the cost embedded within that rate. Without standardised, upfront disclosure against an independent benchmark, consumers and businesses cannot compare providers on a like-for-like basis.

As previewed in last year's report, the 2026 edition introduces a revised scorecard to reflect these distinctions more accurately. The scorecard has been rebased from a 1-5 scale to a 0-5 scale: this means that several jurisdictions are consequently rated one point lower than in 2025, but in most cases this does not indicate deterioration. For direct access, 5/5 now requires a Central Bank settlement account, while the additional "+" recognises jurisdictions that also allow NBPSPs to safeguard customer funds at the Central Bank. For markets that distinguish between domestic and FX payments, an additional "-" has been developed to recognise where NBPSP direct access is possible, but reliance on banks remains to complete a cross-border payment. For price transparency, 5/5 requires comprehensive upfront disclosure alongside active enforcement or full adherence to regulations or regulator-endorsed guidance.

The overall direction is clear. Policy frameworks and payment infrastructure have advanced across both G20 and non-G20 markets, but implementation remains too slow and outcomes for customers remain inconsistent. The final year before the Roadmap's principal deadline should be used to remove structural barriers to NBPSP participation in payment systems, require the full cost of international payments to be disclosed upfront, and ensure that these reforms are implemented and enforced across the corridors where people and businesses move money.



SCALE OF THE PROBLEM AND WHY IT MATTERS

Direct Access

Locked out of the rails: the infrastructure barrier behind slow payments

Six years after the G20 Roadmap for Enhancing Cross-Border Payments set out to make cross-border payments faster, cheaper, more transparent and more inclusive, access to domestic payment infrastructure remains one of the biggest unresolved barriers. A payment may look digital to the customer, but behind the screen it can still depend on multiple intermediaries, sponsor banks and settlement arrangements before money reaches the recipient.

In the G20 itself, only 7 of the 19 markets assessed in this report – Brazil, Indonesia, Japan, Mexico, Türkiye, the UK and the EU – give NBPSPs full direct access to domestic payment systems in 2026. The remaining 12 markets, almost 65% of those covered, still require non-banks to depend on commercial banks for at least part of the clearing or settlement process. That matters because the G20 represents a large share of the global economy: according to the Council on Foreign Relations, its members account for around 85% of global economic output, 75% of global exports and about two-thirds of the world's population.

Direct access is not a technical detail. It determines who can compete, how many intermediaries sit in the payment chain, and how much control a provider has over the speed, reliability and cost of a transfer. Where regulated non-banks cannot connect directly to payment systems, they must rely on banks to process, clear or settle payments on their behalf. That dependence can add operational friction, increase cost, limit resilience and make payment performance contingent on commercial banking relationships rather than the provider's own capability.

The customer does not see most of this. A small business waiting for an international invoice to settle, a student paying rent abroad, or a worker sending money home is unlikely to know whether the provider is connected directly to the local payment system or routing through a sponsor bank. But they feel the outcome: payments that take longer, fail more often, cost more than they should, or become harder to trace when something goes wrong. Infrastructure access is therefore not just a competition issue; it is a customer-outcome issue.

Our own data shows that the impact of direct access can be substantial. In the UK, direct connection to Faster Payments reduced average GBP payment processing times from around 15 minutes to around 15 seconds – a 98% improvement. Following direct access in Hungary, median processing times improved by over 99%, while instant-settled payments increased from 17% to 79%. These are not marginal gains. They show how removing unnecessary intermediaries can materially improve the payment experience.

98%

Reduction in UK payment processing times after securing direct connection to Faster Payments—dropping from 15 minutes to 15 seconds

The same pattern can be seen beyond Europe. Following direct integrations, instant payments rose from 54% to 83% for transfers paid out in AUD in Australia, from 5% to 53% in the Philippines and from 37.4% to 59% in Singapore. Median processing time also improved by 37.5% in Australia, 52.9% in the Philippines and 25% in Singapore. Direct access does not remove every cross-border friction, but it gives regulated providers more control over the part of the payment chain they can improve.

The need for progress is clear from the FSB's 2025 Progress Report. It found that only 35.4% of retail cross-border payment services credited recipients within one hour, and only 67.3% did so within one business day. For businesses, the gap is even wider: only 2.2% of B2B services and 3.5% of B2P services credited recipients within one hour. Those outcomes remain far from the G20's end-2027 speed targets.

The next phase of reform should therefore focus on meaningful direct access, not access in name only. Scheme connectivity can help, but it is incomplete if non-banks still depend on commercial banks for settlement. Domestic access can also be incomplete where providers remain reliant on banks for the international payment leg, FX execution or settlement. The strongest models are those that allow appropriately regulated NBPSPs to connect directly and settle through an account at the central bank.

This does not mean lowering standards. Access should remain risk-based, subject to licensing, operational resilience, safeguarding and financial-crime controls. But where regulated non-banks meet those standards, payment infrastructure should not be reserved for banks by default. If the G20 wants cross-border payments to become faster, cheaper and more resilient by 2027, non-banks cannot remain locked out of the rails that determine how money actually moves.

Price Transparency

Hidden in the exchange rate: The invisible tax on moving money

A payment can be expensive even when it is advertised as free. That is the central problem with hidden FX fees. Consumers and businesses can only make informed choices when the true cost of a product is clearly disclosed, yet in cross-border payments one of the largest costs often remains out of sight. In 2026, consumers and businesses worldwide are projected to lose almost $295 billion to exchange-rate markups they often never see. By 2027, that figure is expected to rise to $318 billion.

These costs are not usually presented as an upfront fee. They are embedded inside the exchange rate. A customer may be told that the transfer fee is zero, or close to zero, while the provider quietly applies a less favourable exchange rate and keeps the difference. The result is an invisible tax on moving money: paid by people sending wages home, families supporting relatives abroad, students paying international expenses and small businesses trading across borders.

The issue is not simply that cross-border payments cost too much. It is that many providers make them look cheaper than they are. Across markets assessed in this report, providers routinely disclose a headline transfer fee while applying an FX markup that is buried in small print, acknowledged without being quantified, hidden behind a tooltip, or not disclosed at all. What customers see is not always what they pay.

The evidence is striking. In Australia, providers applied markups of up to 3.75% on an AUD-USD transfer, in some cases while showing an A$0 transaction fee. In the United States, markups reached 3.07% on a USD-GBP transfer, with providers stating zero or low transaction fees and without clearly disclosing the FX markup. In practice, this means firms can compete on the most visible part of the price while recovering revenue through the least visible part. A customer comparing providers may believe they are choosing the cheapest option, when the real cost sits inside the exchange rate.

This opacity creates serious consumer harm. In 2026, hidden FX fees are expected to reach around $42 billion in the US, $12 billion in the UK and $8 billion in India alone. These are not marginal costs. They are large, recurring and avoidable losses created by a market where too many customers are denied the information they need to compare services properly.

Six years after the G20 committed to improving transparency in cross-border payments, many customers still cannot see the full price before they pay. SWIFT deserves credit for making the payment chain more visible through its Global Payments Innovation (GPI) platform, which surfaces data including the route a payment took, the fees deducted, and details of any currency conversion. Yet banks too often keep that visibility to themselves. While GPI is an industry facing platform, it shows that providers have access to rich FX data, but choose not to surface it – meaning for customers, information disclosure is still difficult to find, understand or compare.

True transparency requires more than listing a transfer fee. It requires providers to show the total cost of the payment upfront, including any FX markup. It also requires that markup be measured against a consistent, independent mid-market rate. Without a common benchmark, customers cannot compare providers on a like-for-like basis, even where some information is disclosed. One provider's "competitive rate" and another provider's "no fee" offer may both conceal very different costs.

This matters because price transparency is the foundation of competition. When customers can see the full cost, providers have to compete on the real price. When they cannot, the market rewards opacity. Hidden FX fees allow expensive providers to appear cheap and transparent providers to appear less competitive simply because they show the cost that others conceal.

The solution is straightforward. The full cost of an international payment, including any FX markup, should be disclosed before the customer authorises the transaction, using an independent mid-market rate as the reference point. Customers should be able to see not only what they pay and what the recipient receives, but how much of their money is being taken in fees and exchange-rate margin. Anything less leaves one of the largest costs in cross-border payments hidden in plain sight.

Provider-level findings in the country chapters show that better transparency is already achievable. Some institutions are broadly aligned with best practice, including by making exchange-rate margins more visible to customers, and this is reflected in the traffic-light assessment. These examples should be recognised as positive market practice and as evidence that fuller disclosure is possible, not theoretical. The priority now should be for this approach to become the market norm, supported where necessary by clearer supervisory expectations and more consistent enforcement.

$295B

Projected global losses to hidden exchange-rate markups in 2026, rising to $318B by 2027

2026 SCORECARD

Updated Scorecard

In the second edition of this report, published in October 2025, we previewed a revised scoring methodology to take effect from this third edition onward. That updated framework is now in use throughout this report.

The revision followed extensive engagement with regulators, policymakers, and industry stakeholders over the preceding year. Feedback highlighted that our original 1-5 scale did not fully capture the nuances in how different jurisdictions enable – or restrict – full direct access for NBPSPs, or price transparency in cross-border payments. In particular, it was difficult to distinguish between jurisdictions that may have good regulation in place, but are not properly enforced, resulting in no change in provider behaviour.

Rationale and continuity

These refinements do not represent a change in the report's underlying philosophy. The G20 Roadmap's objectives remain the benchmark against which all jurisdictions are assessed. Rather, the expanded scale enables more precise measurement of where each G20 member stands on the path toward those objectives, and provides clearer signposting of the specific steps required to progress.

Where a jurisdiction's score has changed between the 2025 and 2026 editions, this may reflect either genuine regulatory progress (or regression) over the past twelve months, or a more accurate placement within the refined scale, or both. Each country profile in this report specifies the reason for any score movement.

Direct Access

The revised Direct Access Scorecard introduces three material changes. First, the highest score of 5/5 now requires that direct access includes a settlement account with the Central Bank. This reflects the principle that meaningful direct access extends beyond technical connectivity to encompass the operational infrastructure necessary for NBPSPs to compete on equal terms with banks. Without a settlement account, non-bank participants remain dependent on commercial banking relationships for settlement, creating a structural competitive disadvantage that undermines the objectives of Building Block 10.

Second, an additional "+" bonus has been introduced to recognise jurisdictions where direct access to payment systems also enables NBPSPs to safeguard customer funds at the Central Bank. This represents the most advanced form of non-bank participation, addressing one of the most significant remaining barriers to true competitive neutrality between banks and NBPSPs.

Finally, for 2026, a "-" marker has been introduced to identify markets where the headline direct-access score may overstate the practical position for cross-border payments. It applies where NBPSPs have some form of direct or scheme-level access to domestic payment systems, but remain dependent on banks for the international payment leg, FX execution or settlement. The marker is not a separate score; it is a qualification showing that domestic payment access has improved, but end-to-end access for cross-border payments remains incomplete.

Price Transparency

The revised Price Transparency Scorecard draws a sharper distinction around enforcement. The previous 5/5 definition required that all providers disclose total costs upfront, including FX markups. The revised 5/5 retains this requirement but adds an explicit enforcement condition: these rules must be actively enforced by authorities, and there must be evidence of a material change in provider behaviour. This change reflects a core finding from our ongoing mystery shopping exercise – that the existence of transparency rules on paper does not, in itself, deliver transparency for end users. Where enforcement is absent or weak, providers continue to obscure costs within inflated exchange rates, and consumers remain unable to make informed comparisons.

The new 4/5 rating now captures jurisdictions where comprehensive disclosure requirements exist – whether through regulation or robust industry guidance endorsed by the regulator – but where enforcement has yet to be demonstrated. This allows us to distinguish between markets that have built the regulatory architecture for transparency and those that have both built it and ensured it functions as intended.

Direct Access

2026 Scorecard

The 2026 direct access rankings are based on a revised scorecard and should not be read as a like-for-like continuation of the 2024 and 2025 tables. This year's methodology applies a more demanding test for full direct access: a 5/5 score now requires NBPSPs to be able to access payment systems directly, for that access to have been adopted in practice, and for participation to include settlement through an account at the Central Bank. The "+" marker recognises the further ability to safeguard customer funds at the Central Bank, while the "-" marker identifies markets where domestic direct access exists but NBPSPs still rely on commercial banks to complete the cross-border or FX leg. As a result, some score changes reflect this more granular 2026 methodology rather than a deterioration in the underlying access framework.

5/5	Banks and NBPSPs are permitted to have direct access to payment systems, it has been adopted by at least 1 NBPSP, and access includes a settlement account with the Central Bank.
4/5	Banks and NBPSPs are permitted to have direct access to payment systems and it has been adopted by at least 1 NBPSP. However, this access does not come with a settlement account at the Central Bank.
3/5	Banks and NBPSPs are permitted to have direct access to payment systems, but it has yet to be adopted by at least 1 NBPSP.
2/5	Licensed banks and some other institutions are permitted to have direct access to payment systems, and authorities are actively working towards widening access to NBPSPs.
1/5	Licensed banks and some other institutions are permitted to have direct access to payment systems, but this is not extended to NBPSPs.
0/5	Only licensed banks are permitted to have direct access to payment rails and no work is underway to change this.
+	NBPSPs are also able to safeguard customer funds at the Central Bank.
−	While NBPSPs are permitted to have direct access, they cannot complete cross-border payments without reliance on commercial banks.

2026 Direct Access Rankings for G20+

Brazil	5/5 +
Philippines	5/5 +
European Union	5/5
Indonesia	5/5
Japan	5/5
Mexico	5/5
Türkiye	5/5
United Arab Emirates	5/5
United Kingdom	5/5
China	4/5 +
Hong Kong	4/5
Malaysia	4/5
Nigeria	4/5
Republic of Korea	4/5
Bangladesh	4/5 −
India	4/5 −
Pakistan	4/5 −
Canada	3/5
France	3/5
Germany	3/5
Italy	3/5
Thailand	3/5
Australia	2/5
South Africa	2/5
Spain	2/5
United States of America	2/5
Argentina	1/5
Guatemala	1/5
Kuwait	0/5
Saudi Arabia	0/5

Price Transparency

2026 Scorecard

The price transparency rankings also use a different scorecard from the one applied in the 2024 and 2025 editions. The 2026 methodology raises the threshold for the highest score by looking beyond the existence of rules or guidance and asking whether those requirements are producing visible customer outcomes. To reach 5/5 requires passing a two-gated test: first, that there is comprehensive full price disclosure rules or regulations that exist, and second, that a majority of firms sampled in at least one category (bank or NBPSP), plus at least one provider in the alternate category, are fully transparent with regards to their FX markups. Previous scores are included for continuity, but movements between years should therefore be interpreted with care: in some cases, the change reflects new policy or regulatory developments; in others, it reflects the rebasing of the scorecard to distinguish more clearly between regulation on paper, supervisory enforcement and provider behaviour in practice.

5/5	All financial service providers are required to disclose the total cost up front to end users, including FX markups, when making a cross-border transfer. The rules or guidance are actively enforced by authorities, and there is evidence of material positive change or compliance in provider behaviour.
4/5	All financial service providers are required to disclose the total cost up front to end users, including FX markups, when making a cross-border transfer. This can be through regulation or robust industry guidance endorsed by the regulator.
3/5	Authorities are actively exploring new action/rules on price transparency to strengthen end user understanding and require all financial service providers to disclose all cross-border payment fees, including FX markups.
2/5	Existing regulation or industry guidance requires price transparency in cross-border payments, including FX markups, but the regulation/guidance is not strong enough to deliver price transparency for end users.
1/5	There are existing regulatory requirements or guidance for price transparency in disclosing all fees associated with cross-border transfers, but does not specify FX markups as a fee or cost to the end user.
0/5	There are no requirements on all financial service providers to disclose all fees associated with a cross-border transfer, including FX markups, and no work is underway to change this.

2026 Price Transparency Rankings for G20+

–	5/5
European Union	4/5
France	4/5
Germany	4/5
India	4/5
Italy	4/5
Spain	4/5
United Kingdom	4/5
Canada*	3/5
Japan	3/5
Nigeria	3/5
Philippines	3/5
South Africa	3/5
Brazil	2/5
Republic of Korea	2/5
United Arab Emirates	2/5
Argentina	1/5
Australia	1/5
Bangladesh	1/5
China	1/5
Hong Kong	1/5
Indonesia	1/5
Kuwait	1/5
Malaysia	1/5
Mexico	1/5
Pakistan	1/5
Saudi Arabia	1/5
Thailand	1/5
Türkiye	1/5
United States of America	1/5
Guatemala	0/5

*Canada's price transparency rules would only apply to banks once implemented, not all financial service providers. However, we expect this to have a positive competitive effect on NBPSPs towards transparency.

Rankings overview

EUROPEAN UNION



Direct Access

2026

Banks and NBPSPs are permitted to have direct access to payment systems, it has been adopted by at least 1 NBPSP, and access includes a settlement account with the Central Bank.

2025

2024

Price Transparency

2026

All financial service providers are required to disclose the total cost up front to end users, including FX markups, when making a cross-border transfer. This can be through regulation or robust industry guidance endorsed by the regulator.

2025

2024

The EU continues to be one of the leading G20 jurisdictions in implementing the G20 Roadmap on direct access and transparency, following notable progress over the past two years.

Following the changes in 2024 to the Settlement Finality Directive (SFD), payment institutions and e-money institutions were brought within the scope of entities eligible to participate in designated payment systems. The first NBPSP, SIA xpate, an e-money institution licensed in Latvia, successfully joined the Bank of Latvia's Electronic Clearing System in April 2025, and several NBPSPs have since gained direct access to payment systems. However, implementation remains uneven. Although most Member States have now transposed the necessary legislation, with Spain being the exception as of August 2026, the vast majority of NBPSPs that have obtained direct access are concentrated in Latvia and Lithuania. Furthermore, while the legal possibility for NBPSPs to safeguard customer funds in Central Bank accounts has been recently introduced, the Eurosystem has already made clear that it will not provide such safeguarding accounts in practice and several non-euro Member State Central Banks have taken a similar position. The EU therefore achieves a 5/5 score for direct access, but does not receive the additional "+" rating.

On transparency, the finalisation of the Payment Services Directive 3 and Payment Services Regulation (PSD3/PSR) negotiations in the first half of 2026 represents an important step forward, as the final PSR text introduces a strong transparency framework requiring FX markups to be disclosed before the transaction is initiated against a live mid-market rate benchmark. While some transparency requirements already applied to all cross-border payments under the Payment Services Directive 2, the new rules will truly extend a more robust transparency framework beyond intra-EU payments to all international payments, including those from the EU to third countries, bringing outgoing remittances into scope. However, the PSD3/PSR package is still in the process of formal adoption and signature, expected by the end of 2026, and a 21 month implementation period will follow. The EU's transparency score therefore remains 4/5 in 2026

European Union

Governance of direct access

The Instant Payments Regulation (IPR) amended the Settlement Finality Directive (SFD) and Payment Services Directive 2 (PSD2) to address the long-standing exclusion of payment institutions and e-money institutions from direct participation in designated payment systems. The IPR recognised that this exclusion prevented non-bank PSPs from providing instant credit transfers efficiently and competitively, and amended the SFD accordingly. The changes also outlined the conditions under which EMIs and PIs can directly participate in payment systems, as well as introduced the option for NBPSPs to safeguard users' funds in an account held with a Central Bank, subject to the discretion of that Central Bank.

The relevant provisions amending the SFD and broadening the scope of entities eligible to participate in designated payment systems had to be transposed into national law by EU Member States by 9 April 2025

Latest regulatory developments and outlook

Since last year, the EU's direct access reforms have moved from legislative change to implementation. The vast majority of Member States have now transposed the necessary legislation, with Spain being the exception as of July 2026.

Within the Eurozone, the Eurosystem has taken a staged approach to implementing NBPSP access. First, in July 2024, it published a harmonised policy confirming that eligible NBPSPs should be able to access T2 and TIPS payment systems, subject to meeting the applicable operational, technical and risk requirements. It also clarified the limits of the reform: accounts in Central Bank payment systems are intended to enable NBPSPs to meet settlement obligations for the current business day and balances would be limited accordingly, and the Eurosystem will not provide accounts for safeguarding users' funds at Central Banks.

To support the implementation of this framework, the European Central Bank (ECB), European Banking Authority (EBA), national Central Banks and national supervisory authorities across the EU subsequently signed a Memorandum of Understanding in December 2025. The MoU strengthens cooperation and information sharing between supervisory authorities and Central Banks in relation to NBPSP participation in Central Bank-operated payment systems. The next step was legal implementation through amendments to the TARGET Guideline, initially planned to enter into force on 16 June 2025, but the Eurosystem postponed their adoption until October 2025 because some euro area Member States had not yet transposed the required SFD and PSD2 amendments into national law.

Within non-euro Member States, implementation of the new rules has been uneven, as some Central Banks haven't adapted access policies for domestic payment systems. For example, as of July 2026, Romania had not adapted Central Bank policies to allow for effective NBPSP direct access. This has created a fragmented implementation landscape outside the euro area, with legal and operational readiness differing significantly between Member States. As a result, NBPSPs' ability to benefit from the EU reforms continues to depend heavily on where they are licensed and which Central Bank-operated payment systems they seek to access.



European Union

Governance of price transparency

The EU's framework governing price transparency has evolved over the years. In 2019, the EU adopted the Cross-Border Payments Regulation 2 (CBPR2) to drive down the cost of cross-border payments within the EU. CBPR2 included several provisions for cross-border payments to be transparent and show "all currency conversion charges" up front to customers. Through this regulation, financial services firms were required to:

- Inform a customer prior to the initiation of the payment transaction, in a clear, neutral and comprehensible manner, of the estimated charges for currency conversion services applicable to the credit transfer.
- Provide the actual exchange rate that will be applied to the transaction as well as all charges related to the currency conversion service.

As a directly applicable Regulation, CBPR2 is legally binding across all 27 EU Member States and does not require national transposition. However, the language in the Regulation has not proven sufficiently robust to ensure price transparency is implemented in practice by industry.

Due to a lack of legal clarity regarding whether FX rate markups constitute "currency conversion charges", firms have continued to use inflated exchange rates while arguing these do not represent a cost to the customer that must be disclosed separately. Furthermore, the CBPR2 rules only applied to intra-EU payments, leaving cross-border payments from the EU to third countries – which include most remittance corridors – out of scope.

In June 2023, the European Commission presented revisions to PSD2, now encompassing two legislative acts – a Third Payment Services Directive (PSD3) and a Payment Services Regulation (PSR). In the Commission's Impact Assessment on PSD2, it emphasised that costs related to currency conversion are an important share of total costs and that without full transparency, it is hard for consumers to compare charges of different providers and to make an informed decision, leading to choosing a provider that may not be the best for them. The Commission also recognised the goals of the G20 Roadmap in this regard and the need to make progress towards them.

Market behaviour

EU cross-border payment hidden fees based on customer payment journey
Data collected May 2026

Provider	FX markup	Transparency rating
Top 4 retail banks by assets held in 2025		
BNP Paribas	0.97%	
Crédit Agricole	0.95%	
Banco Santander	0.61%	
Groupe BPCE/ Banque Populaire	0.00%	
3 popular money transfer operators		
MoneyGram	2.70%	
Ria	3.03%	
WorldRemit	1.53%	

This data was collected by FXC Intelligence; see the appendix for provider-selection details and full methodology.

Consumer impact

The situation of fee transparency and consumer experience across the EU remains uneven in 2026. Providers continue to present exchange rates and transfer fees in ways that make it hard for consumers to understand the full cost of a cross-border payment before initiating the transaction. Most of the largest retail banks in the EU do not clearly identify the FX markup to their customers. In some cases, PSPs present transfers as having €0 transfer fees, making the transaction appear free, while embedding a hidden cost in the exchange rate. Even where providers acknowledge that they may make money from currency conversion, this is often not translated into a monetary amount or percentage that would allow the customer to make an informed comparison.

There are some positive examples in the EU market, such as Groupe BPCE/Banque Populaire, which discloses both the exchange rate and transfer fee clearly upfront. Providers outside this report's sample, including neobanks and newer providers such as N26, bunq and Qonto, are understood to have adopted clearer approaches to upfront pricing, while ING Bank provides a further example from a more established banking group. These examples should be recognised as positive market practice: they demonstrate that firms operating under the EU framework can give customers clearer information on the full cost of a cross-border payment, but this standard has not yet translated consistently across the wider market. However despite this progress, most consumers across the EU continue to receive very different levels of information depending on the provider they use. This prevents them from comparing providers on a like-for-like basis and allows "free" or low-fee transfers to appear cheaper than they are.

European Union

Across the EU, independent research shows that consumers and small and medium-sized enterprises (SMEs) are projected to lose $90.4 billion in hidden FX fees in 2026, rising to $109.7 billion by 2029. These losses reflect the continued gap between the EU's existing transparency framework and the reality of payment journeys across the market. The upcoming PSR rules are designed to address this gap. However, the consumer benefit will depend on active enforcement by national competent authorities, so that transparency is delivered directly in the payment journey and not left for customers to calculate themselves.

Latest regulatory developments and outlook

Following nearly three years of negotiations, the co-legislators reached a final agreement on the PSD3/PSR package in the first quarter of 2026. The final text of the PSR includes a substantially strengthened transparency framework for currency conversion. Specifically, currency conversion charges (FX markups) for credit transfers and remittances must now be expressed both as a monetary amount in the payer's currency and as a percentage markup over an aggregated near-live mid-market exchange rate, disclosed to the customer before the transaction is initiated. This represents a significant advance on the CBPR2 provisions, as it explicitly identifies FX markups as a cost, requires their expression in both absolute and relative terms, and mandates a standardised mid-market benchmark – removing the ambiguity that has allowed providers to conceal costs in inflated exchange rates. The new rules also extend previous price transparency requirements from intra-EU transactions to all transactions within the EU and from the EU to third countries, encompassing all outgoing remittances.

The PSR, as a Regulation, will be directly applicable across all 27 EU Member States upon its entry into force. It is expected to be formally published in the Official Journal towards the end of 2026, with the transparency provisions applying 21 months thereafter, anticipated for 2028. While the new rules will be very clear on the expectations set by the regulators, the consumer benefit will depend on active enforcement by national competent authorities across Member States.

In parallel, some national supervisors have begun to take a more proactive approach to enforcing the existing CBPR2 requirements. In May 2026, the Dutch Authority for the Financial Markets (AFM) issued formal guidance to the Dutch Payments Association, an industry body representing both bank and non-bank payment service providers, clarifying that "currency conversion costs" under Article 5 of CBPR2 include any markup on the exchange rate, and that these costs must be shown clearly and upfront as part of the payment flow – not buried in separate pages or terms and conditions. This represents one of the first concrete supervisory actions by an EU national authority specifically addressing the concealment of FX markups, and signals a direction of travel toward active enforcement even ahead of the PSR's application date. However, this remains an isolated example. In the majority of EU Member States, there has been no comparable enforcement activity on CBPR2's transparency provisions.



Rankings overview

EU FRANCE



Direct Access

2026

Banks and NBPSPs are permitted to have direct access to payment systems, but it has yet to be adopted by at least 1 NBPSP.

2025

2024

Price Transparency

2026

All financial service providers are required to disclose the total cost up front to end users, including FX markups, when making a cross-border transfer. This can be through regulation or robust industry guidance endorsed by the regulator.

2025

2024

France has played an active role in advancing the EU payments agenda, including support for the amendments to the SFD that opened designated payment systems to NBPSPs. However, progress in both direct access and transparency remains closely tied to national implementation and enforcement. The legal framework is now in place, but the impact of the reforms will depend on French authorities ensuring that NBPSPs can access payment systems in practice and that transparency rules are properly enforced in the market.

Although France has incorporated the SFD changes into national law and the Eurosystem's TARGET Guideline amendments have been adopted, no NBPSP has yet been publicly identified as having gained direct access within France. France's 2026 direct access score therefore reflects the revised methodology, which distinguishes between legal eligibility and demonstrated adoption. As NBPSPs are legally eligible to access designated payment systems, but adoption by at least one NBPSP in France has not yet been demonstrated, France is scored 3/5.

France's transparency rating remains unchanged at 4/5. CBPR2 already requires providers to be transparent about currency conversion costs, but French authorities have not prioritised active enforcement of these rules. The finalisation of the PSR represents an important step forward and will strengthen FX markup disclosure requirements once the new rules apply directly in Member States. However, effective enforcement by French authorities will be necessary to ensure that the PSR delivers meaningful transparency for consumers in practice.

France

Governance of direct access

France's direct access framework is shaped by the EU reforms introduced through the IPR, which amended the SFD to bring payment institutions and e-money institutions within the scope of entities eligible to participate in designated payment systems. These changes apply in France and were transposed through Law No. 2025-391 in April 2025, with the French Monetary and Financial Code updated accordingly in Article L. 330-1 II, as amended with effect from 3 May 2025. Payment institutions (11°) and e-money institutions (12°) as well as their branches are among eligible participants, allowing NBPSPs to access local payment systems where they meet the applicable safeguarding, governance, operational and technical requirements.

At the domestic level, France's main retail payment system, CORE, is operated by Systèmes Technologiques d'Echange et de Traitement (STET), which is owned by six major French banks. In addition, access to euro Central Bank money settlement is governed through the Eurosystem's TARGET framework, including TARGET-Banque de France. Together, these frameworks now provide a legal route for NBPSPs to move from indirect, bank-sponsored participation towards direct access to French and Eurosystem payment infrastructure.

Latest regulatory developments and outlook

France has implemented the SFD-related provisions of the IPR, removing the legal barrier to NBPSP participation in designated payment systems. The adoption of the Eurosystem's TARGET Guideline amendments further supports this framework by setting out the route for eligible NBPSPs to access TARGET services, including settlement in Central Bank money.

However, the practical benefits of the reform depend on operational onboarding through the relevant schemes and Central Bank infrastructure. STET has updated its CORE access criteria with effect from 9 April 2025 to make payment and e-money institutions eligible for both direct and indirect participation, and has described the adaptation of its systems to admit these new entrants as one of its two main workstreams in 2025. The contractual and technical groundwork for NBPSP participation in the French clearing layer is now in place. As of June 2026, no NBPSP has been publicly identified as having gained direct access through CORE/STET or Banque de France since the SFD changes entered into effect. France's 2026 direct access score therefore reflects the revised scorecard distinction between legal eligibility and demonstrated adoption: NBPSPs are now legally eligible to access designated payment systems, but adoption by at least one NBPSP in France has not yet been demonstrated.

Governance of price transparency

The EU's Cross-Border Payments Regulation 2 (CBPR2), which is legally binding and does not require national transposition, is the main regulatory vehicle through which transparency in cross-border payments was to be achieved for payments within the EU, including France. The Autorité de Contrôle Prudentiel et de Résolution (ACPR) alongside the Banque de France, oversee compliance with the PSD2 and CBPR2. However, to date, the French authorities have not actively enforced the fee transparency measures, leading to no material change in market behaviour.

Market behaviour

French cross-border payment hidden fees based on customer payment journey
Data collected May 2026

Provider	FX markup	Transparency rating
Top 4 retail banks by assets held in 2025		
Banque Populaire	0.00%	
BNP Paribas	0.97%	
Credit Agricole	0.95%	
Société Générale	1.21%	
3 popular money transfer operators		
Ria	1.64%	
Western Union	1.63%	
WorldRemit	1.55%	

This data was collected by FXC Intelligence; see the appendix for provider-selection details and full methodology.

France

Consumer impact

The consumer experience in France remains inconsistent in 2026. Providers often present exchange rates and transfer fees in ways that obscure the true cost of a cross-border payment. Most major retail banks assessed do not clearly disclose the FX markup, and some PSPs continue to advertise €0 transfer fees while embedding costs in the exchange rate.

For customers, this creates uncertainty at the point of payment. A transfer may appear low-cost or even free, particularly where providers advertise €0 transfer fees, but the real cost is often embedded in the exchange rate. Because this cost is not clearly identified, consumers are left to guess whether they are getting a fair deal. Even where some providers in France acknowledge that they may earn money from currency conversion, this is rarely translated into a clear monetary amount or percentage that would allow customers to understand or compare the cost. As a result, people and businesses are often unable to compare providers on a like-for-like basis before making a payment, and "free" or low-fee transfers can appear cheaper than they are in practice.

There are examples in the French market that show a better user experience is possible. For example, Banque Populaire clearly displays both the exchange rate and the transfer fee upfront in a way that allows the customer to understand the total cost before confirming the transaction. However, this level of transparency is not yet consistent across the market.

Across France, independent research shows that consumers and small and medium-sized enterprises (SMEs) are projected to lose $7.7 billion in hidden FX fees in 2026, rising to $9.4 billion by 2029.

Latest regulatory developments and outlook

The finalisation of the PSD3/PSR negotiations at the EU level represents the next major development for France. Once adopted, the PSR will apply directly in France without national transposition and will require all PSPs to disclose FX markups before the transaction is initiated, both as a monetary amount in the payer's currency and as a percentage markup over an aggregated near-live mid-market exchange rate. The rules will also extend transparency requirements to transactions from the EU to third countries, including outgoing remittances.

The impact of these reforms in France will depend on active enforcement by the ACPR and Banque de France, ensuring that providers update their customer journeys and that FX markups are clearly presented as part of the total cost paid by consumers.



Rankings overview

EU
GERMANY



Direct Access

2026

Banks and NBPSPs are permitted to have direct access to payment systems, but it has yet to be adopted by at least 1 NBPSP.

2025

2024

Price Transparency

2026

All financial service providers are required to disclose the total cost up front to end users, including FX markups, when making a cross-border transfer. This can be through regulation or robust industry guidance endorsed by the regulator.

2025

2024

Germany has implemented the EU reforms introduced through the Instant Payments Regulation (IPR), which amended the Settlement Finality Directive (SFD) to open designated payment systems to NBPSPs. However, as in other euro area Member States, progress in direct access depends on the practical implementation of the Eurosystem's TARGET framework and the onboarding of NBPSPs through the national Central Bank infrastructure. The legal framework is now in place, but the impact of the reforms will depend on whether NBPSPs can access payment systems in practice.

Although Germany has incorporated the SFD changes into national law and the Eurosystem's TARGET Guideline amendments have been adopted, no NBPSP has yet been publicly identified as having gained direct access in Germany. Germany's 2026 direct access score therefore reflects the revised methodology, which distinguishes between legal eligibility and demonstrated adoption. As NBPSPs are legally eligible to access designated payment systems, but adoption by at least one NBPSP in Germany has not yet been demonstrated, Germany is scored 3/5.

Germany's transparency rating remains unchanged at 4/5. CBPR2 already requires providers to be transparent about currency conversion costs, but German authorities have not prioritised active enforcement of these rules. The finalisation of the PSR represents an important step forward and will strengthen FX markup disclosure requirements once the new rules apply directly in Member States. However, effective enforcement by German authorities will be necessary to ensure that the PSR delivers meaningful transparency for consumers in practice.

Germany

Governance of direct access

Germany's direct access framework is governed by the EU reforms introduced through the IPR, which amended the SFD to bring payment institutions and e-money institutions within the scope of entities eligible to participate in designated payment systems. These changes apply in Germany following the adoption of the Gesetz für dringliche Änderungen im Finanzmarkt- und Steuerbereich, published in the Bundesgesetzblatt on 5 March 2025.

At the domestic level, the Deutsche Bundesbank is the relevant national Central Bank for access to TARGET-Bundesbank. Access to euro Central Bank money settlement is governed through the Eurosystem's TARGET framework, including T2 for settlement and TIPS for instant payments. The Deutsche Bundesbank has updated the TARGET-Bundesbank terms and conditions for participation accordingly in October 2025. Eligible NBPSPs can apply for access where they meet the applicable legal, safeguarding, governance, operational and technical requirements.

This framework creates a route for NBPSPs to move away from indirect, bank-sponsored participation and towards direct participation in German and Eurosystem payment infrastructure. However, the scope of access remains limited to settlement activity. The Eurosystem framework does not provide Central Bank safeguarding accounts for users' funds. TARGET account balances for NBPSPs are intended only to meet settlement obligations and are subject to holding limits.

Latest regulatory developments and outlook

The main development over the past year has been the move from EU-level legal reform to national and operational implementation in Germany through TARGET-Bundesbank. However, the reform has not yet translated into demonstrated market adoption in Germany. As of June 2026, no NBPSP has been publicly identified as having gained direct access through TARGET-Bundesbank since the SFD changes entered into effect. The practical impact of the reform will therefore depend on whether NBPSPs can complete operational onboarding through the Bundesbank and meet the Eurosystem's access requirements in practice.

Germany's 2026 direct access score reflects this distinction between legal eligibility and market adoption. NBPSPs are now legally eligible to access designated payment systems, but adoption by at least one NBPSP in Germany has not yet been demonstrated. Further progress will depend on the first NBPSPs successfully moving through the TARGET-Bundesbank access process and using the new framework in practice.

Governance of price transparency

PSD2 was transposed into German national law through the Zahlungsdiensteaufsichtsgesetz (ZAG), entering into force in January 2018. However, the language in the Directive isn't sufficiently robust to ensure price transparency is implemented in practice by industry. Following this, the EU's Cross-Border Payments Regulation 2 (CBPR2), which is legally binding and does not require national transposition, is the main regulatory vehicle through which transparency in cross-border payments was to be achieved for payments within the EU and, consequently, in Germany.

Neither regulators, nor consumer organisations have taken up cases against payment service providers hiding fees in inflated exchange rates. The Federal Financial Supervisory Authority (BaFin) is responsible for overseeing compliance with PSD2 and CBPR2. However, to date, German authorities have not actively enforced the fee transparency measures within the market, which means there has been no material change in market behaviour.

Market behaviour

German cross-border payment hidden fees based on customer journey
Data collected May 2026

Provider	FX markup	Transparency rating
Top 4 retail banks by assets held in 2025		
BW Bank	0.84%	
Commerzbank	1.11%	
Deutsche Bank	1.32%	
DZ Bank	0.45%	
3 popular money transfer operators		
Remitly	1.01%	
Ria	2.23%	
Western Union	1.81%	

This data was collected by FXC Intelligence; see the appendix for provider-selection details and full methodology.

Germany

Consumer impact

Fee transparency in Germany remains weak in 2026. Consumers sending money abroad may be shown a transfer fee, a currency conversion fee, an exchange rate, or only an estimated sending and receiving amount. However, this information often does not make clear what the total cost of the transaction actually is. In some cases, even the exchange rate is not shown during the payment journey at all, leaving the customer to infer the rate themselves.

This creates uncertainty at the point of payment. A transfer may appear low-cost because the visible fee is limited, but the real cost can still be embedded in the exchange rate. Even where providers acknowledge that they may earn money from currency conversion, this is rarely shown as a clear monetary amount or percentage. As a result, consumers and businesses are often unable to compare providers on a like-for-like basis before making a payment and low-fee transfers can appear cheaper than they are in practice.

Across Germany, independent research shows that consumers and small and medium-sized enterprises (SMEs) are projected to lose $13.2 billion in hidden FX fees in 2026, rising to $14.9 billion by 2029.

Latest regulatory developments and outlook

The finalisation of the PSD3/PSR negotiations at the EU level represents the next major development for Germany. Once adopted, the PSR will apply directly in Germany without national transposition and will require PSPs and MTOs to disclose FX markups before the transaction is initiated, both as a monetary amount in the payer's currency and as a percentage markup over an aggregated near-live mid-market exchange rate. The rules will also extend transparency requirements to transactions from the EU to third countries, including outgoing remittances.

The impact of these reforms in Germany will depend on active enforcement by BaFin, ensuring that providers update their customer journeys and that FX markups are clearly presented as part of the total cost paid by consumers.



Rankings overview

EU
ITALY



Direct Access

2026

Banks and NBPSPs are permitted to have direct access to payment systems, but it has yet to be adopted by at least 1 NBPSP.

2025

2024

Price Transparency

2026

All financial service providers are required to disclose the total cost up front to end users, including FX markups, when making a cross-border transfer. This can be through regulation or robust industry guidance endorsed by the regulator.

2025

2024

Italy has implemented the EU reforms introduced through the Instant Payments Regulation (IPR), which amended the Settlement Finality Directive (SFD) to open designated payment systems to NBPSPs. However, as in other euro area Member States, progress in direct access depends on the practical implementation of the Eurosystem's TARGET framework and the onboarding of NBPSPs through national Central Bank infrastructure. The legal framework is now in place, but the impact of the reforms will depend on whether NBPSPs can access payment systems in practice.

Although Italy has incorporated the SFD changes into national law and the Eurosystem's TARGET Guideline amendments have been adopted, no NBPSP has yet been publicly identified as having gained direct access in Italy. Italy's 2026 direct access score therefore reflects the revised methodology, which distinguishes between legal eligibility and demonstrated adoption. As NBPSPs are legally eligible to access designated payment systems, but adoption by at least one NBPSP in Italy has not yet been demonstrated, Italy is scored 3/5.

Italy's transparency rating remains unchanged at 4/5. CBPR2 already requires providers to be transparent about currency conversion costs, but Italian authorities have not prioritised active enforcement of these rules. The finalisation of the PSR represents an important step forward and will strengthen FX markup disclosure requirements once the new rules apply directly in Member States. While there are encouraging signs among banks becoming more transparent in anticipation of the PSR rules, effective enforcement by Italian authorities will be necessary to ensure that the PSR delivers meaningful transparency for all consumers.

Italy

Governance of direct access

Italy's direct access framework is governed by the EU reforms introduced through the IPR, which amended the SFD to bring payment institutions and e-money institutions within the scope of entities eligible to participate in designated payment systems. These changes apply in Italy following national implementation of the SFD and PSD2-related provisions of the IPR, and are reflected operationally in the TARGET-Banca d'Italia participation framework.

At the domestic level, Banca d'Italia is the relevant national Central Bank for access to TARGET-Banca d'Italia. Access to euro Central Bank money settlement is governed through the Eurosystem's TARGET framework, including T2 for settlement and TIPS for instant payments. Banca d'Italia's TARGET-Banca d'Italia documentation has been updated to reflect the new Eurosystem access framework. The TARGET-Banca d'Italia participation contract, published on 8 June 2026, provides that Banca d'Italia may admit non-bank payment service providers established in the EU or EEA as participants, including where they operate through a branch in the EU or EEA. Eligible NBPSPs can apply for access where they meet the applicable legal, governance, operational and technical requirements.

This framework creates a route for NBPSPs to move away from indirect, bank-sponsored participation and towards direct participation in Italian and Eurosystem payment infrastructure. However, the scope of access remains limited to settlement activity. The Eurosystem framework does not provide Central Bank safeguarding accounts for users' funds. TARGET account balances for NBPSPs are intended only to meet settlement obligations and are subject to holding limits.

Latest regulatory developments and outlook

The main development over the past year has been the move from EU-level legal reform to national and operational implementation in Italy through TARGET-Banca d'Italia. However, the reform has not yet translated into demonstrated market adoption in Italy. As of June 2026, no NBPSP has been publicly identified as having gained direct access through TARGET-Banca d'Italia since the SFD changes entered into effect. The practical impact of the reform will therefore depend on whether NBPSPs can complete operational onboarding through Banca d'Italia and meet the Eurosystem's access requirements in practice.

Italy's 2026 direct access score reflects this distinction between legal eligibility and market adoption. NBPSPs are now legally eligible to access designated payment systems, but adoption by at least one NBPSP in Italy has not yet been demonstrated. Further progress will depend on the first NBPSPs successfully moving through the TARGET-Banca d'Italia access process and using the new framework in practice.

Governance of price transparency

The PSD2 was transposed into Italian national law through the Legislative Decree No. 218/2017, coming into force in January 2018. However, the language in the Directive isn't sufficiently robust to ensure price transparency is implemented in practice by industry. Following this, the EU's Cross-Border Payments Regulation 2 (CBPR2), which is legally binding and does not require national transposition, is the main regulatory vehicle through which transparency in cross-border payments was to be achieved for payments within the EU and, consequently, in Italy.

Italy has taken useful steps to improve public understanding of remittance costs. The Centre for International Political Studies (CeSPI) publishes periodic reports monitoring the different cost components involved in sending remittances and progress towards UN Sustainable Development Goal 10, which aims to reduce the transaction costs of remittances to less than 3% by 2030. Banca d'Italia has also taken the positive step of developing financial education materials and a remittance cost calculator to help consumers understand the overall cost of sending money abroad, including the role of exchange rate margins.

However, these initiatives have focused on consumer education and monitoring rather than active enforcement of fee transparency obligations. Despite the existence of CBPR2 and Italy's financial education work, exchange rate margins continue to be an important factor contributing to high remittance costs.

Market behaviour

Italian cross-border payment hidden fees based on customer payment journey
Data collected May 2026

Provider	FX markup	Transparency rating
Top 4 retail banks by assets held in 2025		
Banco BPM	-0.17%	
BPER Banca	-0.68%	
Intesa Sanpaolo	0.03%	
UniCredit*	1.31%	
3 popular money transfer operators		
MoneyGram	1.84%	
Ria	4.25%	
Western Union	1.04%	

This data was collected by FXC Intelligence; see the appendix for provider-selection details and full methodology.

*UniCredit clearly displays all fees and the mid-market FX rate to most of its major currency routes, but this has not yet come into effect for to-USD payments, which is what this report has assessed all providers against. Given this, we have decided to give UniCredit a dark green rating to reflect their efforts and trajectory on cross-border payments transparency.

Italy

Consumer impact

Fee transparency in Italy remains mixed in 2026, but shows encouraging signs as the market study suggests a clearer distinction between banks and money transfer operators. The banks assessed show that better disclosure is achievable today: FXC Intelligence data shows that all four major banks – Banco BPM, BPER Banca, Intesa Sanpaolo and UniCredit – use the mid-market rate and clearly broke down transfer costs for customers in the tested journey. These examples should be recognised as positive market practice, and may indicate that the upcoming PSR rules are already beginning to influence bank behaviour, even before they formally apply.

However, this improvement is not yet visible across the whole market. Money transfer operators continue to present a much less transparent customer experience. In several cases, providers acknowledge that they may make money from currency conversion, but do not disclose the FX mark-up as a clear monetary amount or percentage during the payment flow.

As a result, Italian consumers and businesses are not yet guaranteed full transparency when sending money abroad. The Italian evidence shows that regulatory expectations may already be improving bank behaviour, but unless the PSR rules enter into force and are actively enforced across all provider types, the benefits of transparency will not be felt consistently across the market.

Latest regulatory developments and outlook

The finalisation of the PSD3/PSR negotiations at the EU level represents the next major development for Italy. Once adopted, the PSR will apply directly in Italy without national transposition and will require all PSPs to disclose FX markups before the transaction is initiated, both as a monetary amount in the payer's currency and as a percentage markup over an aggregated near-live mid-market exchange rate. The rules will also extend transparency requirements to transactions from the EU to third countries, including outgoing remittances.

The impact of these reforms in Italy once enforced will underpin the already positive direction Italian provider behaviour is showing, ensuring that providers update their customer journeys and that FX markups are clearly presented as part of the total cost paid by consumers. Italy's existing consumer education initiatives provide a useful basis for improving understanding of remittance costs, and expanding transparent provider behaviour combined with the new supervisory rules would put Italy firmly on track to receive a 5/5 scoring in future.



Expert perspective

A WORD FROM CONSUMERS INTERNATIONAL

From access to outcomes: the consumer test for cross-border payments

Cross-border payment reform can expand choice, reduce costs and strengthen financial inclusion. But faster and more accessible payments will only deliver real value when consumers can understand the full price, compare providers, trust that their money will arrive and obtain help when something goes wrong. Consumers International brings the experience of consumer organisations worldwide to define this consumer test for meaningful progress.

CONSUMERS INTERNATIONAL

Cross-border payments are essential to millions of people supporting families, paying for services and conducting small businesses across borders. But progress should not be judged only by who can access payment infrastructure or what providers are required to disclose. The real test is whether consumers receive better value, understand what they are paying and can use services safely and confidently.

For consumers, transparency is the ability to make an informed choice before paying. To achieve greater transparency, information must be relevant, timely and inclusive. Information should be standardised, comparable, accessible and tested with consumers, including people facing language, disability, financial-literacy or digital-literacy barriers. In cross-border payments, this requires that the total cost – including any foreign exchange markup – the amount the recipient will receive, and the expected delivery time to be presented upfront. Our principles for transparent digital finance have been endorsed by more than 50 organisations – including Wise – and have been used by consumer advocates to drive change in their local markets.

The consumer-risk environment has also evolved, meaning that improved transparency is now only one part of the solution for better digital financial services overall. Consumers International research involving 3,000 consumers across eight countries found that people in more vulnerable circumstances were over twice as likely to have experienced scams – 52% compared with 19%. Transparency alone cannot prevent fraud, but clear information about the provider, recipient, transaction and available redress is an essential part of a safer payment journey.

Responsibility cannot be shifted onto consumers, including when a cross-border payment involves multiple providers or jurisdictions. Providers must ensure clear accountability and timely redress across the payment chain, while consumer organisations should help test payment journeys, identify hidden costs and assess whether new rules produce meaningful improvements.

As the G20 Roadmap approaches its 2027 targets, success should ultimately be measured by what consumers experience: transparent prices, meaningful choice, safer payments and effective support when something goes wrong.

Appendix

Methodology

Direct Access

The Committee on Payments and Market Infrastructures (CPMI) Monitoring Survey provides a detailed analysis of RTGS (Real-Time Gross Settlement) payment system, Faster Payment System (FPS) and Deferred Net Settlement (DNS) system access across different organisation types and compares domestic and foreign entities. The CPMI has categorised various organisation types, which we have grouped together for simplicity in this analysis.

CPMI organisation categorisation	Alternative categorisation
Commercial banks with a local presence	Banks
Commercial banks without a local presence	
Banks other than commercial (e.g. investment banks, payment banks)	
Supervised non-bank financial institutions	Non-Bank PSPs (NBPSPs)
Non-bank e-money issuers (including mobile money providers)	
Money transfer operators	
Post office (if not licensed as a bank)	Other
Central Bank(s)	
DNS system operator(s)	
Faster payments system operator(s)	
RTGS system operators	
National Treasury	
Payment cards network operator(s)	

The 'other' category – public institutions and publicly mandated institutions or organisations, as well as card operators – are not a concern for the purposes of this analysis. It will focus on NBPSP access to domestic RTGS, DNS and FPS. The nuances within the NBPSP category, based on licensing regime, terminology and local requirements, are explored in the report.

Further, the CPMI Monitoring Survey categorises levels of access to a domestic RTGS, DNS and FPS, which again we have grouped together for simplicity in this analysis.

CPMI organisation categorisation	Alternative categorisation
Direct access to a settlement account and Central Bank credit	Direct access
Direct access to a settlement account but not to credit	
Can send transactions directly to the system, without having a settlement account	
Can send transactions indirectly to the system via a direct participant, without having a settlement account	Indirect access
No access allowed	No access

We have defined full direct access as a firm having direct access to the payment system and being in control of its own settlement account at the Central Bank. Any other type of access that still requires working with a sponsor has been defined as indirect access.

Direct Access

2026 Scorecard

The following 'scorecard' system is what we will evaluate all jurisdictions assessed in this report on their progress towards Building Block 10:

"Improving direct access to payment systems by banks, non-banks and payment infrastructures".

Banks and NBPSPs are permitted to have direct access to payment systems, it has been adopted by at least 1 NBPSP, and access includes a settlement account with the Central Bank.
Banks and NBPSPs are permitted to have direct access to payment systems and it has been adopted by at least 1 NBPSP. However, this access does not come with a settlement account at the Central Bank.
Banks and NBPSPs are permitted to have direct access to payment systems, but it has yet to be adopted by at least 1 NBPSP.
Licensed banks and some other institutions are permitted to have direct access to payment systems, and authorities are actively working towards widening access to NBPSPs.
Licensed banks and some other institutions are permitted to have direct access to payment systems, but this is not extended to NBPSPs.
Only licensed banks are permitted to have direct access to payment rails and no work is underway to change this.
NBPSPs are also able to safeguard customer funds at the Central Bank.
While NBPSPs are permitted to have direct access, they cannot complete cross-border payments without reliance on commercial banks.

Price Transparency

Transparency in cross-border payments is defined by the Financial Stability Board (FSB) as PSPs, including both banks and non-bank PSPs, being required to provide a minimum list of information to end-users. The FSB outlines this as "including total transaction costs with relevant charges broken out – sending and receiving fees, FX rate and currency conversion charges; the expected time to deliver funds; tracking of payment status; and terms of service." As outlined above, this analysis will focus specifically on price transparency, i.e. FX rates and currency conversion charges (including FX margins).

Country ranking

For this report's country ranking, we reviewed existing legislation, regulations and any public consultation or ongoing review regarding FX price transparency in all jurisdictions assessed in this report. Where required, we also engaged with national regulators to understand the interpretation of existing rules and regulations. Based on this, we have then ranked each jurisdiction based on the scorecard system outlined below.

Hidden fees projections

Independent research company Edgar, Dunn & Company (EDC) undertook wide ranging economic analysis to assess cross-border payment volume, as well as the amount of hidden fees to move those volumes. This research was undertaken between September and November 2024. It is based on publicly available data, as well as EDC's proprietary model to make predictions from 2024 into 2029.

These projected figures are found throughout this year's report. All figures and projections are in USD, unless specified.

Industry mystery shopping FX rates

The regulatory scorecard is supplemented by independent mystery-shopping research conducted by FXC Intelligence. This research examines what customers can see during an international money transfer and provides evidence of how regulatory requirements and guidance translate into provider behaviour. Mystery-shopping findings inform the assessment of implementation and market conduct but do not, on their own, determine a jurisdiction's score.

FXC Intelligence identified the additional non-G20 markets included in this report in consultation with Wise. The selection was based on FXC's remittance dataset, with country-level flows anchored to official IMF Balance of Payments data. Where a country does not report a dedicated personal-transfers line item, FXC estimates flows using macroeconomic and demographic indicators. Country totals are allocated across corridors primarily using migrant-stock data.

Markets were ranked according to the volume of remittances sent to, or received from, G20 countries. This identified the five largest non-G20 sending markets to the G20 – United Arab Emirates, Hong Kong, Spain, Kuwait and Malaysia – and the five largest receiving markets from the G20 – Philippines, Nigeria, Guatemala, Pakistan and Bangladesh.

In each market, FXC Intelligence reviewed four banks and three Non-Bank Payment Service Providers (NBPSPs).

The banking sample comprises the four largest banks by assets, based on The Banker's Top 1000 World Banks 2025. Where one of these institutions did not provide retail banking services or an online international money-transfer product, the next-largest eligible bank was selected.

The NBPSP sample was selected using a combination of FXC's proprietary remittance data, digital search trends, industry research and local market knowledge. This approach was designed to capture providers with a significant consumer presence, including established international providers and locally important operators. Providers offering digital transfers and transactions denominated in local currency were prioritised to support consistent comparison across markets.

For all banks and NBPSPs captured in this report, the information was collected from each of the featured providers by following their money transfer flows. These are one-off snapshots from the provider's payment journey at a specific point in time. These payment flows are subject to change, and the exchange rate markups may fluctuate.

Data collection

Trained researchers replicated the customer journey for an international money transfer using real customer accounts. Research was conducted through providers' online banking services or mobile applications wherever possible. Where no digital channel was available, data was collected at a branch or agent using a standardised research template. This data collection was run twice per provider.

Researchers simulated a transfer equivalent to USD 1,000 in local currency and followed the customer journey to the point immediately before execution, without completing the payment. In markets where providers only supported transfers denominated in US dollars, researchers simulated a USD transfer equivalent to GBP 1,000.

For each provider, researchers recorded:

- The exchange rate offered;
- Any transfer fees charged to the sender; and
- The date, time and location of collection.

Screenshots were captured throughout the payment journey wherever pricing information appeared, including within tooltips, footnotes and dropdown menus. Screenshots were redacted to remove personal or sensitive information before submission.

Calculating the cost of a transfer

The provider's exchange rate was compared with the contemporaneous mid-market exchange rate supplied by the London Stock Exchange Group. For providers whose rates update in real time, the benchmark rate was recorded at the same time as the rate shown to the customer.

Three principal measures were calculated:

- **Exchange-rate markup:** the percentage difference between the provider's exchange rate and the contemporaneous mid-market rate.
- **Hidden markup fee:** the difference between the theoretical cost of the transfer at the mid-market rate and the cost implied by the provider's exchange rate.
- **Real total cost:** the hidden markup fee plus the stated transaction fee and, where applicable, taxes presented as separate line items.

This approach distinguishes explicit charges shown to customers from implicit costs embedded within an exchange rate.

A tolerance of 0.05 percentage points relative to the mid-market rate was applied. This accounts for minor technical differences, such as short delays in the exchange rates displayed by providers, without materially affecting the transparency assessment.

Quality Assurance

FXC Intelligence applied a centralised quality-assurance process overseen by a designated coordinator. Recorded exchange rates and fees were checked against the supporting screenshots, transfer amounts were validated, and anomalies, such as negative exchange-rate margins, were investigated.

The review also verified that the complete customer journey had been documented, that screenshots were clear and legible, and that relevant tooltips and dropdowns had been opened and captured. Data points that did not meet these requirements were rejected and returned for recollection.

Provider transparency ratings

Each provider was assessed using the report's four-level traffic-light framework:



No transparency

A financial institution conceals foreign exchange markups from the customer. These charges are not disclosed in the payment flow but are instead found outside of the customer experience, e.g. within the terms and conditions.



Low transparency

A financial institution discloses that there is a markup in their exchange rate, but this is not disclosed as a percentage or numerical value.



Some transparency

A financial institution discloses there is a markup to the customer, expressing it as a monetary or percentage value to ease customer understanding. However, this information is hidden behind a tooltip or link to a separate page.



Full transparency

A financial institution communicates the cost of an international money transfer upfront, clearly displaying all fees, including any foreign exchange fees or markups, to the consumer in a clear and comprehensible manner.

The findings presented in each country profile represent a one-off snapshot of the provider's customer journey at the stated collection date. Provider interfaces, fees and exchange-rate markups may subsequently change. FXC's supporting outputs include annotated screenshots, provider-level transparency summaries and the underlying standardised dataset.

Price Transparency

2026 Scorecard

The following 'scorecard' system is what we will evaluate all jurisdictions assessed in this report against their progress towards Building Block 2:

"Implementing international guidance and principles (including transparency of information provided to end users about payment transactions)".

5/5	All financial service providers are required to disclose the total cost up front to end users, including FX markups, when making a cross-border transfer. The rules or guidance are actively enforced by authorities, and there is evidence of material positive change or compliance in provider behaviour.
4/5	All financial service providers are required to disclose the total cost up front to end users, including FX markups, when making a cross-border transfer. This can be through regulation or robust industry guidance endorsed by the regulator.
3/5	Authorities are actively exploring new action/rules on price transparency to strengthen end user understanding and require all financial service providers to disclose all cross-border payment fees, including FX markups.
2/5	Existing regulation or industry guidance requires price transparency in cross-border payments, including FX markups, but the regulation/guidance is not strong enough to deliver price transparency for end users.
1/5	There are existing regulatory requirements or guidance for price transparency in disclosing all fees associated with cross-border transfers, but does not specify FX markups as a fee or cost to the end user.
0/5	There are no requirements on all financial service providers to disclose all fees associated with a cross-border transfer, including FX markups, and no work is underway to change this.

For the purposes of the highest 5/5 price transparency score, the report applies a two-gate test. First, there must be a clear regulatory requirement, or robust regulator-endorsed guidance, requiring relevant providers to disclose the full cost of a cross-border payment upfront, including any FX markup, using an independent mid-market benchmark as the reference point. This is the regulatory gate.

Second, there must be evidence that this framework is translating into customer-facing market behaviour. Because the report cannot test every provider, product and corridor in each market, this outcomes gate is assessed through the consistent FXC Intelligence mystery-shopping sample. A jurisdiction will only be considered for a 5/5 score where there are transparent providers in both categories (banks and NBPSPs), with at least one category having a majority of providers demonstrate full transparency in the tested customer journey (3 banks or 2 NBPSPs).

This threshold is intended to show material behaviour change across both bank and non-bank provider segments. Provider-level findings are treated as evidence of market behaviour changing as a result of compliance with the rules or enforcement of the regulatory gate.

Scorecard recalibration

Both scorecards for direct access and price transparency have been refined for this edition to reflect more precisely whether reforms are delivering practical outcomes for consumers, businesses and NBPSPs. As a result, some year-on-year movements in the rankings should be read as a methodology recalibration rather than a direct change in a market's policy framework. Previous scores are included for continuity, but should therefore be interpreted with care: where a ranking has changed, the country profile explains whether this reflects substantive regulatory progress or regression, or the application of a more granular assessment framework.

Appendix

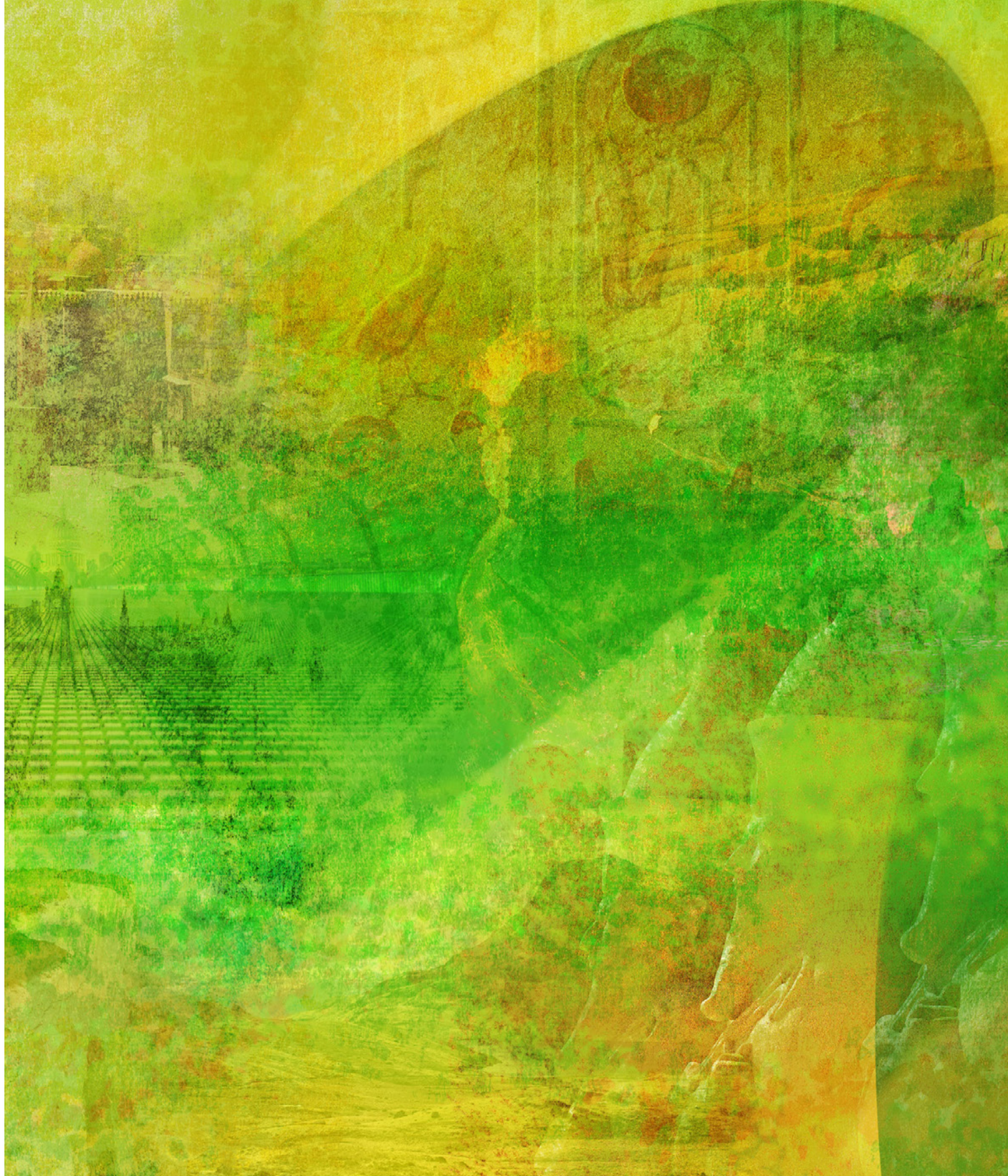
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FXC Intelligence

Edgar, Dunn & Company



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